



BANGLADESH	
Capital city:	Dhaka
Area:	55,598 sq miles (144,000 sq km)
Population:	147,000,000
Official language:	Bengali
Major religions:	Muslim 87%, Hindu 12%, other 1%
Government:	Multiparty democracy
Currency:	Taka
Adult literacy rate:	41%
Life expectancy:	62 years
People per doctor:	4,100
Televisions:	6 per 1,000 people

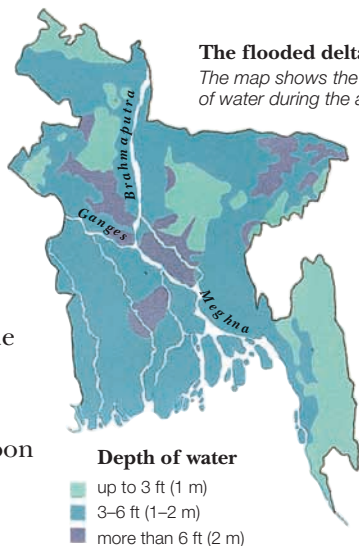
BANGLADESH

IN 1971, EAST PAKISTAN broke away from West Pakistan to become the independent country of Bangladesh. Like Pakistan, it remains a largely Muslim country. The official language is Bengali. Bangladesh is one of the poorest and most crowded countries in the world, suffering from frequent cyclones and floods that cause devastation, especially along the coast. Efforts are being made to control the floods, to slow down the rate of population growth, and to modernize industry and farming.



GROWING JUTE

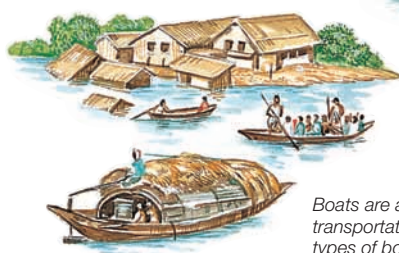
Known to Bangladeshis as “the golden fiber,” jute is a tough, fibrous plant that has proved a valuable source of income for farmers. Jute is used to make sacking, rope, and carpet backing. It has traditionally been Bangladesh’s most important export, but now faces competition from artificial fibers. Rice is a major food crop in Bangladesh, with tea and sugarcane grown for export.



Most Bangladeshi people make their living from fishing and farming. The annual floods provide plenty of fish and keep the land very fertile.



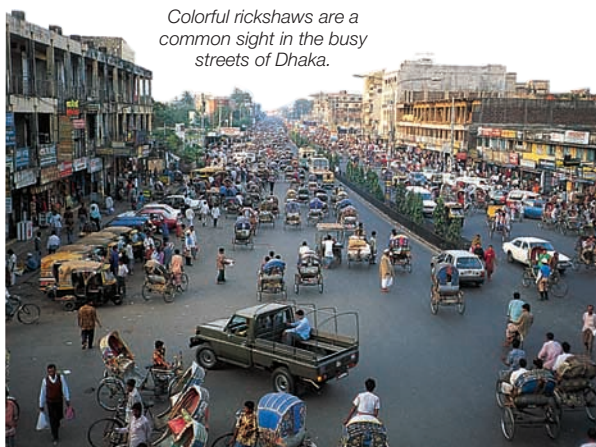
Houses are often raised up on stilts or embankments to protect them from the floods.



Boats are a vital means of transportation. People travel in all types of boat, which are often very crowded. Huge rafts are used to carry jute, bamboo, and other goods.

FLOODED LAND

Much of Bangladesh is made up of the delta (mouth) of three major rivers – the Ganges, Brahmaputra, and Meghna. During the monsoon season (June to October) the rivers flood, and huge amounts of rich silt are left behind, making the soil extremely fertile for farming. But the flooding can also cause devastation, killing many people and animals and sweeping away homes and crops. Despite the risks, most Bangladeshis live in tiny villages scattered across the floodplains.



Colorful rickshaws are a common sight in the busy streets of Dhaka.

LIFE IN THE CITY

Only about a third of Bangladeshis live in cities, mainly in Dhaka, the capital, or the two ports of Chittagong and Khulna. City dwellers can enjoy a higher standard of living than people in the villages, with better homes and facilities such as piped water and electricity supplies. As the cities become more crowded with people looking for work, however, many new arrivals are being forced to live in slums and shantytowns.



HEALTH CARE

Despite government health care programs, the death rate in Bangladesh is very high, especially among children in remote, rural areas. This is largely due to poor diet and to unclean water, which helps spread diseases such as cholera. Medical teams travel around the country immunizing people from disease and teaching them about diet and birth control.

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